

Study Abroad Mentor Platform — Product Concept & Competitive Analysis

Oct 1, 2026 · @Husnain Aslam

1. Executive summary

The product: a marketplace where verified students and graduates living abroad sell affordable guidance to students in Pakistan and India who want to study abroad. AI tools for universities, scholarships and admission steps support it. Launch with one corridor: Pakistan → Germany.

Why it can work

- **Consultants are expensive.** One Pakistani consultancy lists all-inclusive packages at PKR 150,000–500,000+ ([DM International](#)). Here, a single mentor call costs PKR 3,000–7,500 and a full Germany package PKR 25,000–40,000.
- **Trust in agents is low.** Complaints against study-abroad firms in Punjab rose from 400 in 2021 to 1,409 in 2024 ([Express Tribune](#)).
- **Germany suits peer guidance.** Major German universities do not take admissions through agents ([ICCI, Jul 2026](#)), so applicants already apply themselves and need step-by-step help. The same report notes a 14% rise in Pakistani students in Germany over two years.
- **There is a gap.** None of the competitors we checked combines verified peer mentors, a Pakistan focus, in-platform chat and video, and AI tools (section 7).

How it earns: about 20% of each booking (15% from the mentor, 5% from the student). Partner referrals, university lead fees, an AI Pro plan and accommodation commissions come on top (section 6).

The biggest risk is legal, not technical. UK Student-visa holders, New Zealand student-visa holders and US F-1 students may not freelance. In Germany, a student needs the foreigners' office (Ausländerbehörde) to approve self-employment. Mentors also must not sell personal visa advice, which is a regulated profession in the UK, Australia, Canada and New Zealand (section 9).

Recommended next step: validate demand with real students and a first group of mentors. Then build a narrow MVP: verified gigs, chat and video, held payments in PKR, and the AI document checklist (section 11).

Technical words are explained in the glossary (section 12).

2. The problem

Two groups of students have a problem, and each can solve the other's.

Students who want to go abroad pay too much for advice they cannot check.

- **High fees.** A Pakistani consultancy lists PKR 50,000–200,000 for document preparation and PKR 150,000–500,000+ for all-inclusive packages ([DM International](#)). Another source gives PKR 75,000 as an average visa-consultant fee ([IGL](#)).
- **"Free" advice has a hidden price.** Many free consultants are paid by universities, often 10–15% of first-year tuition ([GradPilot](#)). They may push the universities that pay them, not the ones that fit the student.
- **Fraud.** Victims report fees kept instead of forwarded, fake receipts and fake "scholarship" charges ([Express Tribune](#)).
- **Scattered information.** Rules live on university websites, government portals and Facebook groups, and much of it is out of date.

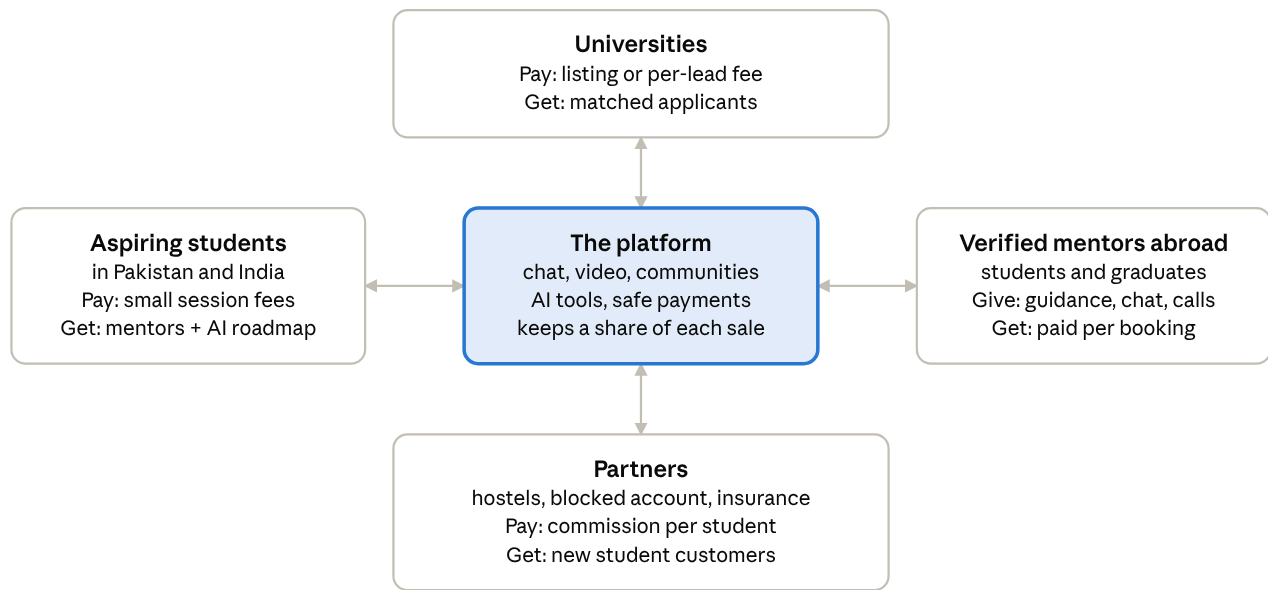
Students who are already abroad need income. The founder's observation is that many spend their first months without a job while they settle in. They hold exactly the knowledge the first group needs: how they chose a university, which documents they sent and what went wrong. However, many of them cannot legally be paid: UK and New Zealand student-visa holders, US F-1 students, and students in Germany without approval from the foreigners' office (section 9). Early paid mentors will mostly be graduates, residents and approved students. For context, Germany's minimum wage is €13.90 per hour in 2026 ([BMAS](#)), and the suggested prices in section 6 let a mentor earn more than that per hour of call time.

The opportunity: a trusted place where these two groups meet, pay safely and get reliable information, for a fraction of a consultant's fee.

3. Core idea and how it works

The platform is a two-sided marketplace. Students pay verified mentors for guidance, and universities and service partners pay to reach those students.

Students, mentors, universities and partners all meet on one platform



how the platform works · 5 groups

Money comes in from students, universities and partners. The platform keeps a share and pays mentors for their time.

A student's journey

1. **Sign up and onboard.** Fill in one form: target countries, field, grades, test scores, budget and publications.
2. **Get AI suggestions.** The platform suggests countries, universities and scholarships, each linked to its official page.
3. **Explore mentors and communities.** See verified mentors for the chosen countries, sorted by rating and match, and join country communities.
4. **Book and pay.** Book a gig. The payment is held until the session is done.
5. **Talk on the platform.** Chat and video happen inside the site, and contact details are blocked.
6. **Confirm and review.** Confirm the session and leave a review. The mentor's money is released in the next weekly payout.
7. **Follow the roadmap.** The AI checklist guides the remaining steps: applications, finances and the visa appointment.
8. **Arrive.** Book accommodation with the student discount and join the city's community.

A mentor's journey

1. **Sign up and verify.** Provide a university email, proof of enrolment and proof of the right to earn (section 9).
2. **Create gigs.** Set prices within the suggested bands (section 6).
3. **Deliver.** Answer bookings through chat and video calls.
4. **Get paid.** Receive weekly payouts after sessions are confirmed, and build up ratings.

4. Core features (the founder's vision)

The founder's idea breaks down into eleven modules, served through role-based panels for students, mentors, universities and admins. Each row describes the module from the user's point of view.

#	Module	What the user can do	Main user
1	Smart onboarding	Fill in one form: target countries (multi-select), field of interest, grades, test scores, budget, publications. The platform uses it to suggest countries, universities, scholarships and mentors.	Student
2	Mentor marketplace (gigs)	Verified students abroad publish gigs such as "Admission guidance for TU Munich" or "Document checklist review", each with a price. Students filter by country, university and rating, then book.	Mentor, student
3	Mentor verification and profiles	Mentors prove they are enrolled (university email plus enrolment certificate). Profiles show university, programme, languages, ratings and reviews.	Mentor, admin

#	Module	What the user can do	Main user
4	In-platform chat and video	WhatsApp-style messages and video calls inside the site. Phone numbers, emails and social handles are blocked, so both sides stay on the platform (as on Upwork).	Student, mentor
5	Communities	Country and university groups, like Facebook Groups. Mentors, students and university representatives can create groups, post questions and answer them.	Everyone
6	AI university and scholarship finder	An AI agent matches the student's profile to universities and to government and university scholarships. It shows a short summary plus a link to the official page, and refreshes the data on a schedule.	Student
7	AI document checklist and admission roadmap	For a chosen country and university, AI lists the required documents and every step (application, language test, finances, visa). Guidance only: the platform does not process documents.	Student
8	AI professor finder	For research students (MS/PhD), AI matches interests such as NLP or bioinformatics to professors at target universities, using their publications and official university pages.	Student

#	Module	What the user can do	Main user
9	Accommodation finder	An AI agent lists hotels, guest houses and hostels near the university. Bookings through the platform get a 5% student discount; the property pays the platform a 10% commission.	Student, property
10	University portal	Universities register, publish programmes and are shown to matching students.	University
11	Admin panel	Approve mentors, handle disputes and refunds, moderate communities and keep data current.	Admin

The positioning matters: this is an information-sharing marketplace, not a consultancy. It guides students and connects them with people who have done it; it does not apply or submit documents on their behalf.

5. Ten new features that add value and revenue

These ten features each help a user and bring in money, and each copies a model that already works for a real company. They are not in the founder's original list. The five features that close gaps with competitors are listed separately in section 8.

#	Feature	What it is	Who benefits	How it makes money	Proven by
1	Mentor Pro	A paid plan for mentors: profile analytics, discount coupons and a lower commission (the lower commission is our idea; Seller Plus does not offer it).	Busy mentors	Monthly subscription	Fiverr Seller Plus (\$25 or \$49/month)

#	Feature	What it is	Who benefits	How it makes money	Proven by
2	Boosted listings	Mentors or universities accept a higher commission in return for a higher search ranking. Results are clearly marked "Sponsored".	Mentors, universities	Extra commission per booking	Hostelworld's paid "Elevate" ranking raised its effective commission to 16.2% (FY2025 results)
3	Ask-a-Senior	A student pays a small fee for one written answer within 48 hours; if no answer arrives, the refund is automatic.	Students on a budget	Fee per question	Topmate's "Priority DM"
4	Group webinars	Ticketed live sessions, such as "Applying to TU Munich in 2027", run by top mentors or scholarship winners.	Students, mentors	Ticket share	AbroadMates group sessions; MyGermanUniversity runs about 100 webinars a year
5	University Ambassador Rooms	Universities pay a yearly fee for their verified students to answer prospects in a branded room.	Universities, mentors	Annual B2B fee	UCAS reports that 65% of students who chat with an ambassador add that university as an application choice

#	Feature	What it is	Who benefits	How it makes money	Proven by
6	Arrival Kit	One page of vetted partner links for a blocked account, health insurance, an eSIM and housing; a single checkout can come later.	Students	Partner fees, negotiated directly. Fintiba has an agency partner programme and Airalo pays affiliates 10%. The €10 bonuses from Expatrio, Fintiba and Coracle are personal refer-a-friend schemes, not business deals	Expatrio , Fintiba , Coracle , Airalo
7	Housing Shield	A mentor who lives in the city video-inspects a flat and checks the lease before the student pays a deposit.	Students (scam protection), mentors	Flat fee per inspection	HousingAnywhere charges tenants 25–40% of the first month's rent for protection
8	AI application pre-check	AI checks the SOP, CV and admission checklist for gaps, then a mentor signs it off. Visa forms are excluded (section 9).	Students, mentors	Included in AI Pro (section 6), plus a mentor review fee	Ambitio Pro sells AI admission tools for ₹11,999 a year
9	AI interview practice	Voice practice for university admission interviews, followed by a mentor debrief. It is practice only and never predicts a visa result.	Students	Included in AI Pro (section 6)	AbroBot offers AI voice interview practice

#	Feature	What it is	Who benefits	How it makes money	Proven by
10	German Speaking Buddy	Mentors offer A1–B1 German conversation practice and Goethe exam practice.	Students, mentors	Commission per lesson	Preply keeps 100% of a new student's trial lesson, then takes 33% falling to 18%

Recommended order: start with features 3 and 6, which need little code and fit the MVP. Features 5 and 2 come later, when there is traffic to sell.

6. Revenue model

The platform keeps about 20% of each booking: a 15% commission from the mentor and a 5% service fee from the student. Fiverr takes more: 20% from sellers plus 5.5% from buyers, and \$3.50 extra on orders under \$200 ([Fiverr](#), [HireInSouth](#)). The mentor's 15% is also below Preply's 18–33%, and Preply keeps all of a new student's trial lesson ([Preply](#)).

Per hour of call time, mentors keep about €15–22, above Germany's €13.90 minimum wage. Free intros, follow-ups and preparation time lower this, and mentors pay their own tax.

Suggested mentor prices

Prices are in PKR, converted at €1 ≈ PKR 314 ([rate on 1 Oct 2026](#)). Mentors set their own price inside a suggested band, so new mentors start low and raise prices as reviews come in.

Gig	Price (PKR)	≈ €	Note
Ask-a-Senior: one written answer within 48 hours	1,000–1,500	3–5	Entry product
30-minute video call	3,000–4,000	10–13	Mentor keeps about €16–22 per hour of call time after commission
60-minute video call	5,500–7,500	18–24	Mentor keeps about €15–20 per hour of call time; minimum wage is €13.90 (BMAS)

Gig	Price (PKR)	≈ €	Note
7-day chat pass	4,000–6,000	13–19	Mentor promises a reply within 24 hours
30-day chat pass	10,000–15,000	32–48	About 2.5 times the 7-day pass
SOP + CV review, 2 rounds	7,000–12,000	22–38	Consultants charge PKR 50,000–200,000 for document preparation
Mock admission interview	4,000–5,000	13–16	Practice only, no visa advice (section 9)
Germany package: shortlist, uni-assist checklist, 2 calls, 1 review, 30-day chat	25,000–40,000	80–127	A visa consultant averages PKR 75,000 (IGL)

How a mentor picks a price inside the band. The platform can suggest a price automatically, and the mentor can change it.

- Fewer than 5 reviews: the bottom of the band, to win the first bookings.
- 5 or more reviews averaging 4.5★ or higher: the middle of the band.
- 20 or more reviews, or a scholarship holder: the top of the band.

Worked example: one 60-minute call at PKR 6,000

Step	PKR
Mentor's listed price	6,000
+ Student service fee (5%)	300
= Student pays	6,300
Mentor receives (price – 15% commission)	5,100 (≈ €16)
Payment gateway fee (about 1.5% for wallets and Raast; about PKR 213 by card)	about 95
Platform keeps, before payout fees, tax and running costs (900 + 300 – 95)	about 1,105

Break-even: at about PKR 1,100 per call, every PKR 100,000 of monthly running costs needs about 90 such calls a month.

How chat is priced

Do not charge per message, because it rewards padding and leads to disputes. Sell chat in three shapes instead:

- **Single answers** (Ask-a-Senior), like Topmate's paid "Priority DM".
- **Chat passes** of 7 or 30 days.
- **A free 72-hour follow-up thread** after every paid call, so the student can ask what they forgot.

Held payments (escrow) and refunds

Escrow means the platform holds the student's money until the service is delivered. It protects both sides.

1. The student pays. The platform holds the money; it does not go to the mentor yet.
2. The session happens on the platform, so there is a record.
3. The student confirms, or the order confirms itself after 72 hours. Fiverr does the same after 3 days ([Fiverr](#)).
4. After a short dispute window, mentors are paid weekly.

Refund rules:

- Mentor does not show up: 100% refund, including the service fee.
- Student cancels 24 hours or more before the session: 100% refund. Less than 24 hours: 50%.
- Dispute raised within 72 hours: an admin decides using the in-platform chat and call logs.
- Deals made outside the platform: no protection. This is one more reason for users to stay on the platform.

All revenue streams

Stream	Who pays	Market benchmark
Session commission + service fee	Mentor 15%, student 5%	Fiverr: 20% seller + 5.5% buyer, + \$3.50 on orders under \$200

Stream	Who pays	Market benchmark
Accommodation: hotels and guest houses	The property	Booking.com: 10–25%, about 15% on average (Lodgify)
Accommodation: student housing	The property	HousingAnywhere: 8% from landlords (HA); UK student-housing marketplaces: under 5% on average (SHC, 2021)
Partner fees (Arrival Kit)	Blocked-account, insurance, loan and eSIM providers	Negotiated deal by deal. Fintiba runs an agency partner programme (Fintiba); Airalo pays affiliates 10% (Airalo). Public refer-a-friend bonuses (€10 from Expatrio, Fintiba and Coracle; \$300 from MPOWER) are for personal use only, so they show scale, not business terms
University leads	Universities, mainly private ones in Germany	US benchmark: \$140 per enquiry, \$2,900 per enrolment (AllCampus)
AI Pro plan	Students	Core AI tools stay free. AI Pro (suggested PKR 1,500–3,000 per intake) adds unlimited assistant use, reminders, the application pre-check and interview practice. For comparison, Yocket Premium costs ₹59,999–₹1,34,999 (Yocket) and Ambitio Pro ₹11,999 a year
Mentor Pro, boosted listings	Mentors, universities	Fiverr Seller Plus: \$25 or \$49 a month

A note on the accommodation plan. The plan is a 5% discount for the student and a 10% commission from the property. If the platform funds the discount from its own commission, it keeps only 5%. It is better to make the 5% discount part of the property's

own deal. 10% is fair for hotels and guest houses, but UK student-housing marketplaces average under 5% (range 1.5–15%).

How every stakeholder benefits

Stakeholder	What they pay	What they get
Student	Session price + 5% fee	Guidance at a small share of a consultant's price, with refunds if things go wrong
Mentor	15% commission	Flexible income above minimum wage per hour, and reviews that build a reputation
University	Lead or ambassador-room fees	Better-prepared applicants from new markets
Partner (housing, finance, eSIM)	Referral commission	Customers at the moment they need the service
Platform	Gateway fees and running costs	About 20% of every booking, plus partner income

Collecting and paying out money

- **Stripe and PayPal are not options in Pakistan.** Stripe does not support Pakistan ([Stripe](#)), and PayPal is unavailable to Pakistani residents ([PublicLens](#)).
- **Collect through a local gateway.** Safepay charges 2.9% + Rs30 for cards and 1.5% for Raast and mobile wallets; confirm which wallets it supports ([Safepay](#)).
- **Do not keep wallet balances.** Holding stored money needs a State Bank of Pakistan e-money licence with PKR 200 million capital ([SBP](#)). Hold each order's money separately until the session is confirmed. Before launch, confirm with Safepay whether payouts can be delayed or split, and ask a lawyer whether the platform may hold mentors' money.
- **Pay mentors simply at first.** In the MVP, pay mentors in PKR to Pakistani bank accounts; whether most mentors keep one is unverified. Later, a US or UK company can use Stripe Connect cross-border payouts ([Stripe](#)) or Payoneer mass payouts to 190+ countries ([Payoneer](#)).
- **Ask a lawyer** whether marketplace payouts need State Bank approval before launch.

7. Competitor analysis

No competitor we checked combines verified peer mentors, a Pakistan focus, in-platform chat and video, and AI tools. The strongest players are Indian and do not target Pakistan. The most dangerous substitute is a general mentor marketplace such as Topmate, where students abroad can already sell sessions. Figures below are what each company reports about itself, checked on 1 October 2026.

Direct competitors (same job: guide students to study abroad)

Competitor	What it is	How it earns	Serves Pakistan?	What we learn from it
Gradbees	Marketplace of vetted current students at top global universities; "300+" mentors	Pay per session. Its pages show both ₹1,200 for 45 minutes and ₹2,000 + GST for 60 minutes (mentors page); it says 100% of the fee goes to mentors	Not mentioned (prices in INR)	The closest model to ours. Proves students pay for peer sessions; offers a full refund if unhappy
AbroadMates	All-in-one study-abroad mentorship, pitched as an agency alternative	20- and 40-minute calls plus bundles; prices not public	Not in its country list	Group sessions with scholarship winners; 4.8★ average rating (self-reported)
Yocket	Indian study-abroad platform with 800,000+ users	Free tools; premium counselling costs ₹59,999–₹1,34,999, with monthly instalments from ₹5,999 (Yocket Premium)	Not mentioned	Admits & Rejects database, university and scholarship finders, AI SOP builder

Competitor	What it is	How it earns	Serves Pakistan?	What we learn from it
GermanyPath	Free Pakistan → Germany guides plus an AI consultant	7 free AI messages, then PKR 4,000 for 3 months or PKR 7,500 for 6 months, paid by Easypaisa	Yes, the same corridor	Students pay small sums by mobile wallet; it collects Easypaisa payments manually. It has no human mentors, which is our opening

Also worth watching, all India-focused AI or counselling platforms: [Leap Scholar](#) (free counselling, loans, "150,000+ admits"), [Leverage Edu](#) (AI coach, housing, loans), [AbroBot](#) (AI counsellor, admission-chance model, voice interview practice) and Ambitio (AI admissions copilot, \$2M seed round in 2025 per [Inc42](#)).

Indirect competitors (solve part of the problem)

Competitor	What it is	How it earns	Why it matters to us
Topmate , MentorCruise , ADPList	General mentor marketplaces. Topmate has a "Study Abroad" category	Topmate takes about 10% + 2.9% processing (third-party estimate, Peerseek); MentorCruise sells \$39–\$149 one-off sessions	Biggest substitute: mentors can sell there today. We must win on trust, focus and AI tools
Unibuddy	Prospective students chat with current-student ambassadors; 500+ universities (self-reported)	Universities pay for it	AI moderation blocks harmful messages (help page). Universities will compare our university portal to it

Competitor	What it is	How it earns	Why it matters to us
Amber , UniAcco	Student-housing marketplaces; Amber lists 2M+ beds in 250+ cities	Commission from properties	UniAcco's "No Visa, No Pay" guarantee. Both overlap our accommodation agent
Mastersportal , MyGermanUniversity	Free course search: 95,000+ master's programmes; 24,059 German programmes	Paid promotion by universities	Their data is deep. Link to them rather than rebuilding a course database
Local consultancies: AEO Pakistan , Edvoy Lahore , IDP Pakistan	Offices in major Pakistani cities; Edvoy is free for students	University commissions, test fees, student fees	Offline trust and brand. IDP's app tracks applications
Free channels: DAAD Information Centre Islamabad , Facebook groups, StudyAbroad.pk	Seminars, peer Q&A, scholarship listings	Free	Our communities must be better moderated and more reliable than free groups
ApexApply	AI professor matching across "3M+ faculty", with AI-drafted outreach emails	Pricing not public	Overlaps our professor finder

8. Five "cherry on top" features from competitors

Competitors offer twelve notable features that this product does not have yet. These five matter most to South Asian students, and a small team can build each one. They cover interface, AI, safety, payments and data.

The remaining gaps, for later: an admission-chance predictor ([AbroBot](#)), AI voice interview practice, housing guarantees such as "No Visa, No Pay" ([UniAcco](#)), professor "accepting students" signals ([ApexApply](#)), group webinars, paid written questions

answered later and monthly mentoring subscriptions ([MentorCruise](#)). Several already appear in section 5.

1. "My Journey" tracker with reminders (interface)

- **Seen at:** [AbroBot](#) (deadline reminders) and [IDP Pakistan](#)'s IDP Live app (application tracking).
- **What it is:** one dashboard that turns the AI checklist into dated tasks, such as the uni-assist application, blocked account and visa appointment. It shows progress, and the student can share it with their mentor.
- **Why it matters:** one missed deadline can cost a whole intake. GermanyPath reports embassy appointment waits of months in Pakistan ([GermanyPath](#)).
- **How to build it:** a `tasks` table filled from the checklist, plus a daily scheduled job that sends email or push reminders.

2. Automatic session notes and action items (AI)

- **Seen at:** [ADPList](#), which turns recorded sessions into a transcript, summary and action points.
- **What it is:** with both users' consent, the call is recorded and turned into a written summary. Its action items flow into the student's tracker.
- **Why it matters:** a cheap session feels more valuable when the student keeps a written plan. The record also helps settle disputes.
- **How to build it:** record through the video provider (LiveKit supports recording), convert speech to text with a model such as Whisper, then summarise it with an LLM. Show a clear consent banner before recording.

3. AI moderation on top of contact blocking (safety)

- **Seen at:** [Unibuddy](#), which blocks harmful messages and alerts admins, and shows ambassadors' first names only ([Unibuddy safety](#)).
- **What it is:** every message is checked for harassment, sexual content and "pay me outside the platform" scams. A flagged message is hidden and goes to an admin queue, and repeat offenders are blocked. Profiles show first names only until a session is booked.
- **Why it matters:** families must trust a platform where strangers talk, and some bachelor's applicants are under 18. Simple phone-number filters are easy to dodge ("zero three zero zero..."), so AI catches what rules miss.

- **How to build it:** a moderation API next to the regular-expression contact filter, plus a "Moderation" tab in the admin panel.

4. Free intro call, instalments and an automatic money-back promise (payments and trust)

- **Seen at:** [MentorCruise](#) (free first call), [Gradbees](#) (full refund), GermanyPath (Easypaisa checkout) and [Yocket](#) (monthly instalments).
- **What it is:** mentors can choose to offer a free 10–15 minute intro call. Larger packages, such as the Germany package, can be paid in two or three instalments. The refund is automatic if the mentor does not show up, and students pay by local wallet or card.
- **Why it matters:** price-sensitive students will not pay strangers in advance. Local wallets remove the need for a card.
- **How to build it:** a ledger table with `held`, `released` and `refunded` states, updated by the payment gateway's webhooks (automatic messages the gateway sends to your server).

5. Verified Admits & Rejects board (data and community)

- **Seen at:** [Yocket](#), whose admits and rejects network lets applicants compare profiles.
- **What it is:** mentors and alumni post anonymous profiles (degree, CGPA, IELTS, German level) with the decision for each programme. An admin checks the decision letter, marks the entry "verified", then deletes the letter.
- **Why it matters:** existing data comes from Indian applicants. Pakistani students need evidence from Pakistani profiles applying to German programmes. The board also brings search-engine traffic and, later, data for an admission-chance predictor.
- **How to build it:** a form, a filterable table and manual checks at first.

Runner-up: ask accommodation partners for a "No Visa, No Pay" promise, as [UniAcco](#) offers.

9. Key considerations and risks

The biggest risk is legal, not technical. In several countries, the students you want as paid mentors are not allowed to be self-employed. This is factual research, not legal advice; confirm each point with a lawyer before launch.

Can student mentors legally be paid?

Country	Rule for international students (checked Oct 2026)	What the platform should do
Germany	140 full or 280 half days of work a year (or 20 hours a week during lectures). Any self-employment needs approval from the foreigners' office (Make it in Germany)	Pay a mentor only after they upload that approval
UK	Student-visa holders "cannot be self-employed" (GOV.UK); Graduate-visa holders can (GOV.UK)	Accept Graduate-visa holders, permanent residents and citizens; not Student-visa holders
USA	F-1 students need authorisation for off-campus work (Study in the States); universities treat freelancing as work (WashU)	Exclude F-1 students from paid gigs
Canada	Up to 24 hours a week off campus if eligible; self-employed hours count toward that limit (IRCC)	Allow, with a signed hours declaration and an hours log
Australia	48 hours per fortnight during study periods (Study NSW); no official statement found on self-employment	Allow with an hours declaration; confirm with a local lawyer
New Zealand	Up to 25 hours a week, but "international students cannot be self-employed" (Immigration NZ)	Exclude student-visa holders

The practical answer is to verify each mentor's **right to earn**, not only their enrolment. Graduates on work visas, permanent residents and citizens widen the mentor pool safely.

What mentors may and may not sell

Giving individual immigration advice for money is a regulated profession in the UK ([legislation.gov.uk](#)), Australia ([OMARA](#)), Canada ([IRPA s91](#)) and New Zealand ([IAA](#)). Germany's Legal Services Act (RDG) also limits paid legal help in individual cases ([IHK Darmstadt](#)). The UK regulator notes that general information for many people is not immigration advice ([IAA practice note](#)).

- **Allowed in paid gigs:** choosing universities, SOP and CV feedback, admission checklists, life abroad, personal experience, and links to official visa pages.
- **Not allowed in paid gigs:** judging a buyer's visa chances, filling in or reviewing visa forms, and strategy after a visa refusal.
- **AI features:** visa checklists stay general and always link to official sources.

Other risks and how to handle them

Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation
Under-18 users	Bachelor's applicants may be minors talking to adult strangers. Fiverr is 18+ and lets ages 13–17 in only through a parent's account (Fiverr); Outschool keeps all teacher contact on-platform and visible to parents (Outschool)	18+ by default. Under-18s only through a parent-linked account, with a parent present or the session recorded. ID checks for mentors
Privacy law	Pakistan has no comprehensive data-protection law in force yet (Chambers, Mar 2026). The EU's GDPR applies to users in the EU (EC). India's DPDP Rules were notified in Nov 2025 (PIB)	Follow GDPR-level practice from day one: a clear privacy notice, consent, collecting only what is needed, and deleting enrolment proofs after verification
Professor data	Work emails count as personal data under GDPR. The ORCID public API may not be used in revenue-generating products (ORCID)	Use OpenAlex (open CC0 data) for names, affiliations and research topics. Link to the official profile instead of collecting emails. Offer a removal form

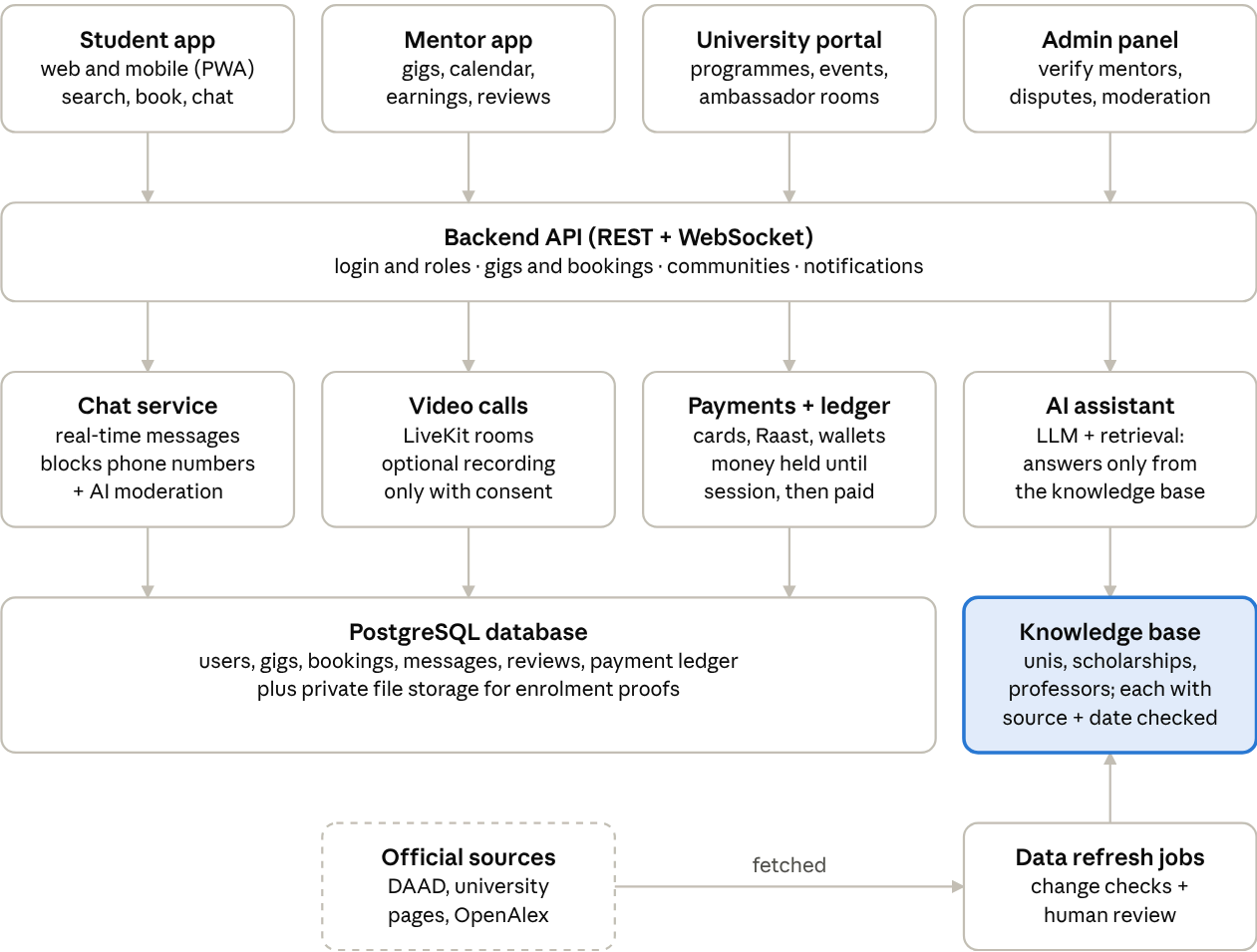
Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation
Payments	Stripe and PayPal are not available in Pakistan; storing wallet balances needs a State Bank licence (section 6). Students in India may not be able to pay a Pakistani gateway easily	Use a licensed local gateway and hold money per order, not in wallets. Before any India launch, confirm how Indian students will pay; it may need a separate company or gateway
Users leaving the platform (disintermediation)	Upwork requires clients to keep work and payments on Upwork for two years, or pay a conversion fee of 13.5% of the freelancer's estimated annual earnings (Upwork). Fiverr bans sharing contacts to do business off-platform	Contact filter plus AI moderation; warn first, then suspend. EU fairness rules require clear terms and explained restrictions (CCPC), so tell users messages are scanned and allow appeals
Out-of-date information	Wrong deadlines or scholarship amounts can ruin an application	Use official sources only (DAAD scholarship database , university pages). Store a source URL and "last verified" date on every record. Check weekly and flag anything older than about 90 days
Trust and fraud	Study-abroad fraud is common in Pakistan (Express Tribune)	Verification badges, held payments, and reviews only from completed bookings. Never promise admissions, visas or jobs
Accommodation	10% is high for student housing, though below Booking.com's average of about 15% for hotels. Listing scams are common	Hotels and guest houses: 10% is fair. Student housing: expect less, since UK student-housing marketplaces average under 5%. Verify listings, and consider Housing Shield (section 5)

Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation
Taxes	The EU's DAC7 rules require platforms to report sellers' income (EC). The platform's own fees may be subject to Pakistani sales tax and income tax	Ask an accountant about Pakistani taxes before launch. Mentors declare their income where they live. Plan for DAC7 registration before paying many EU-based mentors
Competition	Mentors can sell on Topmate today	Win on demand, trust, a narrow corridor and AI tools that general marketplaces lack

10. Suggested technical architecture

A simple, well-known stack is enough. It needs one backend API, one PostgreSQL database, and four specialised services for chat, video, payments and AI.

One backend API serves every panel; the AI answers only from checked data



suggested architecture · 5 layers

Read it top to bottom. Each app talks only to the API, and the API calls the services. The AI never answers from memory alone: it looks up checked records in the knowledge base and shows their source links.

Suggested tools

Part	Suggested tool	Why it suits a small team
Frontend	Next.js (React) + Tailwind CSS, built as a PWA	One codebase for web and mobile; public pages such as scholarships can rank on Google

Part	Suggested tool	Why it suits a small team
Backend API	Python FastAPI (or Node.js NestJS)	FastAPI fits the AI work well; NestJS suits a team that wants TypeScript everywhere
Database	PostgreSQL with the pgvector extension	Normal tables plus AI search in a single database
Real-time chat	WebSockets (for example Socket.IO) + Redis	Messages arrive instantly; Redis lets several servers share them
Video	LiveKit (open-source video calling)	Ready-made rooms, recording and audio-only calls for weak connections
Payments	Safepay + webhooks	Works in Pakistan; webhooks update the payment ledger automatically
AI	An LLM API + retrieval (RAG) over the knowledge base	Answers stay tied to checked data and cite their sources
Background jobs	A scheduler such as Celery or BullMQ	Weekly data checks, deadline reminders and payouts
Hosting	Managed services (for example Vercel + a managed PostgreSQL)	Less server maintenance while the team is small

Performance on Pakistani internet

- Compress images and serve them through a CDN (a network of servers close to users).
- Offer audio-only calls when the connection is weak.
- Load chat history page by page, not all at once.
- Add database indexes on the columns students filter by: country, university and rating.

Example: a first contact-detail filter

A regular expression (a text pattern that code can search for) catches the obvious cases. AI moderation (section 8) catches tricks such as numbers written in words.

```
import re

# Pakistani mobile numbers: 0300-1234567, +92 300 1234567,
# 0300 123 4567, 00923001234567, wa.me/923001234567
PHONE = re.compile(r"(\+92|0092|92|0)[\s-]?3\d{2}[\s-]??\d{3}[\s-]??\d{4}")
EMAIL = re.compile(r"[\w.+-]+@[\w-]+\.[\w.]+")

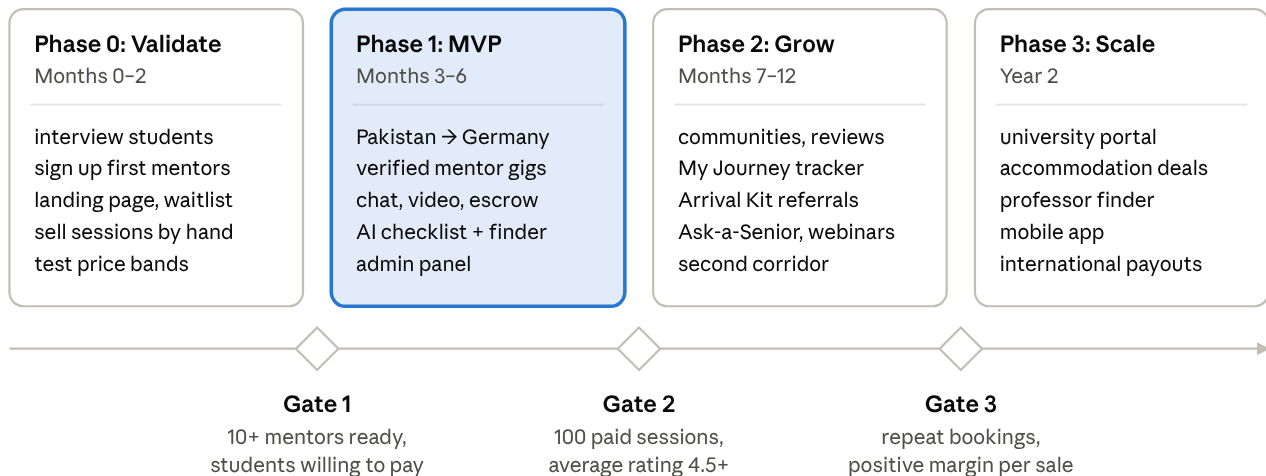
def has_contact_info(message: str) -> bool:
    return bool(PHONE.search(message) or EMAIL.search(message))

# Still needed: rules for German (+49) and Indian (+91) numbers,
# social-media @handles, and numbers written as words.
```

11. Phased roadmap

Build in four phases, and move on only when the gate before the next phase is passed. The suggested gates are: Gate 1, at least 10 mentors ready and students willing to pay; Gate 2, 100 paid sessions with an average rating of 4.5 or more; Gate 3, repeat bookings and a positive margin on each sale. Adjust these targets once real numbers come in.

Prove one corridor first; add countries only after each gate is passed



roadmap · 4 phases, 3 gates

Phase 1 stays on one corridor so the team learns quickly and spends little. New countries come only after Gate 2, and each new country needs its own mentor eligibility check (section 9).

First steps

- ☐ Interview 20–30 students who plan to study in Germany: what they pay now, and what they would pay a mentor
- ☐ Recruit about 10 mentors in Germany and check each one's right to earn
- ☐ Ask a Pakistani lawyer about collecting payments and paying mentors
- ☐ Launch a landing page with a waitlist
- ☐ Run the first paid sessions by hand with a simple form and a video link, before writing platform code

Getting the first students

Students already gather in a few places, so start where they are.

- **Online groups** for Pakistani students heading to Germany: mentors answer questions for free and link to the waitlist.
- **University societies** in Pakistan: free webinars with mentors for final-year students.
- **Short videos** by mentors on YouTube, TikTok and Instagram, such as "my German application in 60 seconds".
- **Search-friendly pages:** public scholarship and university guides that rank on Google and lead to mentors.
- **Referral credit:** a student who invites a friend gets credit toward their next session.

12. Glossary

Term	Meaning in this document
Affiliate or referral fee	A commission a partner pays for each customer you send them
API	The set of web addresses (endpoints) the app calls to read or change data on the server
Ausländerbehörde	Germany's local foreigners' office, which issues residence permits and work approvals
B2B	Business-to-business: selling to organisations (such as universities) rather than to individuals

Term	Meaning in this document
Blocked account (Sperrkonto)	A German bank account where a student deposits a year of living costs in advance, as proof for the visa
CC0	A licence that puts data in the public domain, so anyone may use it for any purpose
CDN	A network of servers in many places that delivers files from a location close to the user
Commission (take rate)	The share of each sale that a marketplace keeps
Corridor	One origin country to one destination country, such as Pakistan → Germany
DAC7	EU tax rules that require platforms to report how much their sellers earn
Disintermediation	When buyer and seller skip the platform and deal directly, so the platform earns nothing
E-money licence	Permission from the State Bank of Pakistan to hold customers' money as stored balances
Effective commission	The average share a platform actually keeps, after discounts and paid boosts
Escrow (held payment)	The platform holds the buyer's money until the service is delivered
GDPR	The European Union's data-protection law
Gig	A fixed service at a set price, as on Fiverr
GST	India's Goods and Services Tax, added to some prices
Intake	One admission round, such as a university's winter semester
Lead generation	Charging a university for each interested student it receives
Ledger	A table that records every money movement: paid, held, released, refunded

Term	Meaning in this document
LLM	Large language model: the AI that reads and writes text, such as Claude or GPT
MVP	Minimum viable product: the smallest version that real users can try and pay for
Payment gateway	A service that accepts card and wallet payments for a website, such as Safepay
PWA	Progressive web app: a website that can be installed on a phone like an app
Raast	Pakistan's instant payment system, run by the State Bank of Pakistan
RAG (retrieval-augmented generation)	The AI first finds relevant records in your database, then answers using only those records
Regular expression (regex)	A text pattern that code can search for, such as the shape of a phone number
Seed round	A startup's first sizeable investment from outside investors
Settlement account	The account where a payment gateway collects money before passing it on
SOP	Statement of purpose: the motivation essay in a university application
uni-assist	A service many German universities use to check international applications
Webhook	An automatic message one system sends to another when something happens, for example "payment received"
WebSocket	A connection that stays open, so the server can push new chat messages instantly

13. Sources

All pages were opened on 1 October 2026. Company figures are self-reported unless noted.

Competitors and market

- [Gradbees](#) and its [mentors page](#)
- [AbroadMates](#)
- [Yocket](#), [Yocket Premium](#), [Yocket Connect](#)
- [GermanyPath](#)
- [Leap Scholar](#), [Leverage Edu](#), [AbroBot](#), [Ambitio Pro](#), [Inc42 on Ambitio](#)
- [Unibuddy](#), [Unibuddy AI moderation](#), [Unibuddy ambassador safety](#), [UCAS peer-to-peer engagement](#)
- [Topmate](#), [Topmate Priority DM](#), [Peerseek fee comparison](#), [MentorCruise](#), [ADPList](#)
- [Amber](#), [UniAcco](#)
- [Mastersportal](#), [MyGermanUniversity](#)
- [AEO Pakistan](#), [Edvoy Lahore](#), [IDP Pakistan](#), [DAAD Information Centre Islamabad](#), [StudyAbroad.pk](#), [ApexApply](#)

Consultant fees, pricing and payments

- [DM International: consultant fees](#), [IGL: visa consultant checklist](#), [GradPilot: agent commissions](#)
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- [Lodgify: Booking.com fees](#), [Hostelworld 2025 results](#), [HousingAnywhere landlord fee](#), [HousingAnywhere tenant fee](#), [Student Housing Consultancy](#)
- [Expatrio referral terms](#), [Fintiba referral](#), [Coracle bonus](#), [MPOWER referral](#), [Airalo affiliate FAQ](#), [AllCampus: lead generation](#)
- [Exchange rate, 1 Oct 2026](#), [BMAS: German minimum wage](#)
- [Stripe global availability](#), [Stripe Connect cross-border payouts](#), [PublicLens: PayPal in Pakistan](#), [Safepay pricing](#), [SBP e-money regulations](#), [Payoneer marketplaces](#)

Law, safety and data

- [Make it in Germany: working as a student](#), [GOV.UK Student visa](#), [GOV.UK Graduate visa](#), [Study in the States: working](#), [WashU: entrepreneurial activities](#), [IRCC: work off campus](#), [Study NSW: work rights](#), [Immigration NZ: working on a student visa](#)
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- [Chambers: Pakistan data protection 2026](#), [European Commission: data protection](#), [PIB: India DPDP Rules](#), [European Commission: DAC7](#)
- [OpenAlex pricing and access](#), [ORCID public API terms](#), [DAAD scholarship database](#)
- [Fiverr Community Standards](#), [Upwork: payments outside Upwork](#), [Outschool: learner safety](#), [CCPC: EU platform-to-business rules](#)
- [Upwork: conversion fee](#)